Elon Musk is a South African-born American business magnate, investor, and engineer who has become one of the most consequential and controversial figures of the 21st century. As the CEO of Tesla and SpaceX, the owner of X (formerly Twitter), and the founder of ventures like Neuralink and xAI, he has built a sprawling business empire that spans electric vehicles, space exploration, artificial intelligence, and social media. In 2026, he became the first person in history to amass a trillion-dollar fortune, a milestone driven largely by the public listing of SpaceX. His life story is one of immense ambition, radical risk-taking, and profound disruption, shaped by a difficult childhood and an unwavering drive to reshape humanity's future.

📜 Early Life and Education

Elon Reeve Musk was born on June 28, 1971, in Pretoria, South Africa, to a Canadian-born mother, Maye Musk (a model and dietitian), and a South African father, Errol Musk (an engineer). His childhood was turbulent. He was a "freakishly bright kid" who was brutally bullied at school—on one occasion, he was beaten so severely he required hospitalization. He also endured what biographers describe as psychological abuse from his father, a trauma that Musk has said contributed to his intense drive and difficulty with empathy.

Musk's intellectual talents emerged early. At the age of 12, he taught himself computer programming and sold the source code for a video game called *Blastar* to a computer magazine for about $500. He briefly attended the University of Pretoria before moving to Canada at age 17 to attend Queen's University, acquiring Canadian citizenship through his mother. Two years later, he transferred to the University of Pennsylvania, where he earned dual bachelor's degrees in economics from the Wharton School and physics from the College of Arts and Sciences. In 1995, he moved to California to begin a PhD in applied physics at Stanford University but dropped out after just two days to pursue his entrepreneurial ambitions during the dot-com boom.

🚀 The Business Empire

Musk's career is defined by a series of ventures that have each sought to disrupt massive, entrenched industries. His approach has been to retain large ownership stakes in his companies as their valuations soared, rather than simply cashing out.

Zip2 and the Path to PayPal

Musk's first major business venture was **Zip2**, an online publishing and business-directory company he co-founded with his brother, Kimbal, in 1995. The company helped newspapers bring local business listings and maps online, with Musk writing much of the software himself. Zip2 was sold in 1999 for more than $300 million, earning Musk about $22 million. He used this capital to launch **X.com**, an online banking startup, in 1999. X.com later merged with a competitor to become **PayPal**, which revolutionized digital payments. When eBay acquired PayPal in 2002 for $1.5 billion, Musk, who had been forced out as CEO, received roughly $176 million—the fortune he would use to fund his next, far more ambitious ventures.

SpaceX: Revolutionizing Spaceflight

In 2002, Musk founded **SpaceX (Space Exploration Technologies Corp.)** , investing roughly $100 million of his own money and taking on the roles of CEO and chief engineer. His stated goal was to dramatically reduce the cost of launching payloads into space and ultimately help make humanity a multiplanetary species. The early years were perilous; Musk later admitted he believed the company had less than a one-in-ten chance of success. After three failed launches, the fourth flight of the **Falcon 1** rocket reached orbit in September 2008, saving the company. This breakthrough led to a $1.6 billion NASA contract for resupply missions to the International Space Station, which SpaceX

first accomplished in 2012. The company has since developed the Falcon 9 (the first orbital-class rocket capable of reflight), the Dragon spacecraft, and the massive **Starship** system, designed for missions to Mars. In June 2026, SpaceX went public in what was the largest IPO in history, briefly valuing the company at over $2.4 trillion and propelling Musk to trillionaire status.

Tesla and the Electric Vehicle Revolution
Musk joined **Tesla Motors** in 2004 as chairman and lead investor, a year after the company was founded, investing approximately $80 million. He assumed the role of CEO in October 2008, leading the company through near-bankruptcy to become the world's most valuable automaker. Under his leadership, Tesla popularized the electric vehicle with models like the Model S, Model 3, Model X, and Model Y, and expanded into energy storage and solar products (through the acquisition of **SolarCity**, a company Musk had helped launch in 2006). Tesla's success forced the global auto industry to accelerate its transition to electric power. Musk has held the titles of "Technoking of Tesla" and "Imperator of Mars," reflecting his unconventional style. He temporarily stepped down as chairman in 2018 for three years to settle fraud charges with the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC).

Neuralink, The Boring Company, and xAI
Beyond his flagship companies, Musk has founded several other ventures. **Neuralink**, founded in 2016, is developing brain-computer interface implants with the goal of helping people with severe paralysis and, ultimately, achieving a symbiosis between human and artificial intelligence. **The Boring Company**, also founded in 2016, was spun out of SpaceX in 2018 to dig underground tunnels for high-speed transportation (the "Hyperloop") and alleviate urban traffic.

In 2023, Musk founded **xAI**, an artificial intelligence company, to compete with OpenAI (which he had co-founded in 2015 but left in 2018). xAI developed the **Grok** chatbot. In a series of consolidating moves, xAI acquired X (the social media platform Musk bought for $44 billion in 2022) in a deal valuing the combined entity at over $110 billion. Then, in early 2026, SpaceX acquired xAI, creating what analysts informally called the "Muskonomy"—a privately-held behemoth encompassing rockets, AI, social media, and brain implants, with speculation that Tesla could eventually be folded in as well.

💰 Wealth and the First Trillionaire

Musk's wealth is overwhelmingly tied to his ownership stakes in his companies, particularly SpaceX and Tesla. He became the first person to surpass a net worth of $500 billion in October 2025. On June 12, 2026, when SpaceX shares began trading publicly, his net worth surged past $1 trillion, making him the world's first trillionaire in history. His fortune peaked at an estimated $1.45 trillion before settling to around $1.1 trillion by late June 2026, a sum larger than the GDP of any African economy. He owns roughly 38% of SpaceX, which constitutes about 70% of his total wealth.

👯 Personal Life

Musk's personal life is complex and has been the subject of intense public scrutiny. He has been married twice and is the father of at least 14 children with four different women.

- **Justine Wilson:** Musk married Canadian author Justine Wilson in 2000; they divorced in 2008. They had six children, including their first son, Nevada, who died of Sudden Infant Death Syndrome at 10 weeks old. Their other children include twins Vivian and Griffin, and triplets Kai, Saxon, and Damian. Vivian is estranged from her father and has legally changed her name to disassociate from him.

- **Talulah Riley:** Musk married British actress Talulah Riley in 2010. They divorced in 2012, remarried in 2013, and divorced again in 2016.
- **Grimes:** Musk had an on-and-off relationship with Canadian musician Grimes, with whom he has three children.
- **Shivon Zilis:** Musk has four children with Shivon Zilis, a tech executive who has held roles at Neuralink and appeared at his side at political events. Their relationship, which included twins conceived via IVF in 2021, ended abruptly in late 2026, with Zilis stating it went "from in love to let go in a week with no warning".
- **Ashley St. Clair:** In 2025, it was revealed that Musk had a child, Romulus, with conservative influencer Ashley St. Clair.

Musk has spoken openly about being on the autism spectrum and has discussed his use of ketamine to manage depression, which he says is beneficial for his business travels and creative thinking.

⚖️ Controversies and Legal Battles

Musk's career has been punctuated by legal and regulatory battles. In 2018, he settled SEC fraud charges over a tweet claiming he had "funding secured" to take Tesla private, paying a $20 million fine and agreeing to step down as Tesla chairman for three years. He has also faced numerous lawsuits and investigations related to Tesla's Autopilot system, labor practices, and his own social media conduct.

A major legal defeat came in May 2026, when a California jury unanimously rejected his lawsuit against OpenAI, CEO Sam Altman, and President Greg Brockman. Musk had accused them of manipulating him into donating $38 million and abandoning the company's original nonprofit mission. The jury found that Musk had waited too long to file his claims, which were essentially expired. This loss underscored the enduring feud between Musk and the AI company he helped found, which he now competes against with xAI.

🏛️ Political Involvement and DOGE

Musk's political engagement intensified in the mid-2020s. He became a prominent supporter of Donald Trump and, in 2025, was tapped to lead the **Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE)** , an initiative aimed at drastically cutting federal spending. His tenure was highly controversial, marked by theatrical gestures—such as brandishing a chainsaw as a symbol of slashing "waste"—and massive cuts to international humanitarian aid. His approach was characterized by a techno-libertarian ideology that equated destruction with efficiency.

By mid-2026, Musk had expressed some regret, saying he "got carried away" with Trump and that he should have focused on his companies instead of running DOGE. His political activities have drawn scrutiny from Democrats, who, after winning control of Congress in the 2026 midterms, signaled plans to investigate his months at DOGE, potential conflicts of interest with government contracts, and the use of Starlink in Ukraine.

🌎 Legacy and Impact

Elon Musk's legacy is inextricably linked to his companies' audacious missions: electrifying the global automobile fleet (Tesla), making humanity multiplanetary (SpaceX), merging minds with machines (Neuralink), and understanding the true nature of the universe (xAI). He is the real-life inspiration for

Tony Stark, a comparison he has both embraced and deflected. His management style is famously demanding, pushing teams to achieve what seems impossible on aggressive timelines.

Yet his legacy is also deeply contested. His critics point to his inflammatory social media posts, his combative stance toward regulators and the press, his divisive political interventions, and the human costs of his "hardcore" work culture. He is a figure of profound contradictions: a visionary who has advanced sustainable energy and spaceflight, and a provocateur whose behavior has alarmed many. What remains undeniable is that Musk has reshaped entire industries and, in the process, has forced the world to confront fundamental questions about technology, power, and the future of humanity itself.